

Flyovers and congestion

What has been shown about journey time, air pollution and noise?

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“reduce delays, emissions, and noise pollution”

Infrastructure Malta, Msida Creek statement, 28 October 2024

Marsa Junction completed 2021 · Msida Creek flyover opened 2025; wider works ongoing

VERDICT: NOT SUBSTANTIATED

Marsa figures reported; underlying surveys unavailable.

TL;DR

Infrastructure Malta makes different claims about two different junction projects. For Marsa, its 2021 completion release reports 79% less travel time and reductions in particulate matter, NOx and CO2. For Msida, the 2024 statement describes lower delays, emissions and noise as expected benefits. The public material located does not include the underlying Marsa surveys, and the wider Msida project remained unfinished at the review date.

- 1

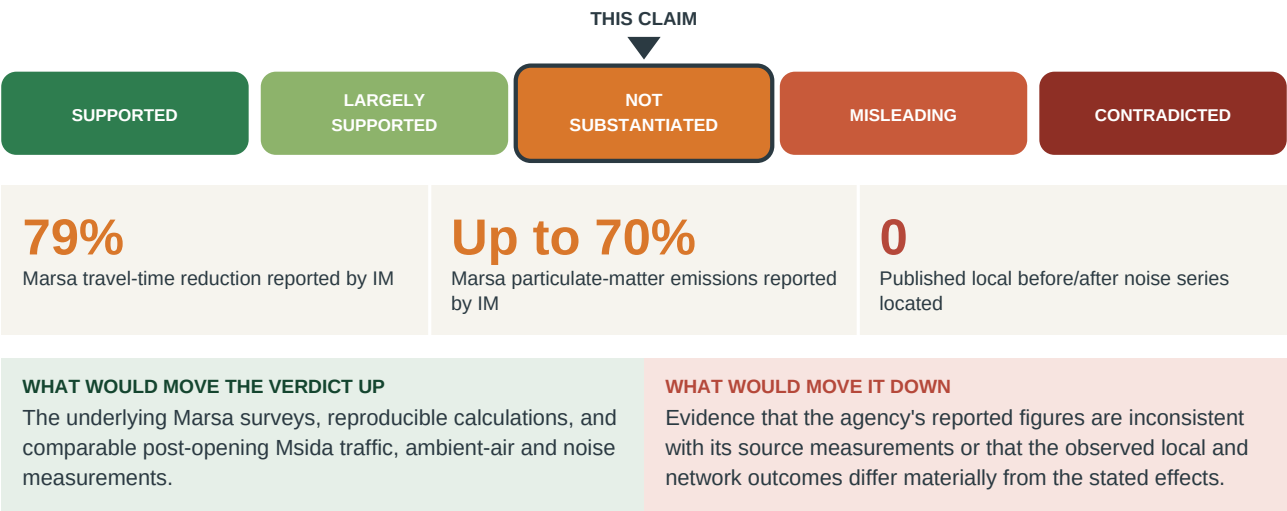
Marsa has reported figures, not a public dataset. The completion release reports 79% less travel time, up to 70% less particulate matter, 52% less NOx and 50% less CO2. It does not link the survey series or calculation.
- 2

An interview points to surveys. In November 2021, an IM spokesperson said periodic surveys confirmed benefits; the surveys themselves and their methods were not published in the article.
- 3

Msida's statement preceded construction. In October 2024, before works began, IM called the new flyover “a critical move to reduce delays, emissions, and noise pollution”. It opened to vehicles in December 2025; other project works continued in 2026.
- 4

Noise is unverified. No comparable before-and-after noise measurements were found for either location.
- 5

Verdict: not substantiated. The outcomes are plausible and Marsa has agency-reported numbers, but the available public evidence cannot independently verify the combined claim.



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1

Wording and project stages

Infrastructure Malta's 28 October 2024 Msida statement says the area has congestion that affects air quality and noise, and describes building a new flyover to replace the traffic-light-controlled junction as “a critical move to reduce delays, emissions, and noise pollution” [1]. The same page says initial work “will focus on strengthening the Msida waterfront quay” and gives 2027 for completion: works had not begun, so the stated reductions were expected effects, not measured results. The vehicle flyover opened in December 2025, but the wider project continued through 2026 [3].

THE MARSA AGENCY CLAIM

The 15 April 2021 Marsa completion release reports “79%” less travel time and “up to 70%” less air pollution. It also lists 52% less nitrogen oxides and 50% less carbon dioxide [2].

These are Infrastructure Malta's reported project benefits. The source page does not link the underlying traffic surveys, calculation files, pollutant inputs or uncertainty. It also says that removing traffic-light waiting times “is resulting in significant air quality improvements in Paola and Marsa”, a statement about local air quality for which it cites no monitoring data.

The two cases have different timelines. Marsa is a completed, multi-level project. Msida's road flyover began operating while other elements, including public spaces and the canal, were still being delivered. A single combined claim therefore needs separate evidence for each location and outcome.

Source	What it establishes	Evidence limit
IM Marsa release, 2021	Agency's stated time and emissions benefits	No linked survey or method
Times of Malta, 2021	IM spokesperson says periodic surveys confirm benefits	Surveys not reproduced; secondary account
ERA Msida file	Planning baseline and forecast rationale	2019 observations; no post-opening test
PM, December 2025	Flyover entered vehicle use; project continued	No outcome measurements

A planning document and an EIA-screening decision are not after-the-fact environmental measurements. The ERA file records the project process and planning description [4]. Its existence neither proves benefits nor shows that the impacts are absent.

2

What the public records show

Marsa's completion release gives four headline percentages. A Times of Malta report later quoted an Infrastructure Malta spokesperson saying periodic surveys confirmed time and air-quality benefits, even though junction users were reported to be more than 19% above the 2013 level [5]. This is a useful lead to the agency's monitoring, but the surveys and methods were not provided in the article.

Outcome	Published statement	Needed for independent checking
Marsa travel time	79% reduction reported	Routes, survey dates, peak periods, distribution and adjustment for demand
Marsa air pollution	PM up to 70%; NOx 52%; CO2 50% reductions reported	Separate emissions estimates from monitor concentrations; publish inputs and locations
Msida delay / emissions / noise	Expected reductions stated in 2024	Comparable data after full road layout is operating
Noise, both sites	No local before/after result located	Comparable noise levels, sites, times and traffic conditions

What do the Marsa percentages measure?

UNDERLYING SERIES NOT PUBLIC

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

Infrastructure Malta describes reduced travel time and emissions, and later said its periodic traffic surveys confirmed benefits [2, 5]. The road layout separates several movements and removes the old traffic-light system, a plausible way to reduce delay for some routes.

EVIDENCE AGAINST

The source release does not identify the survey route, dates, traffic periods, baseline adjustment, pollutant model or uncertainty. "Emissions" does not mean a measured drop in ambient concentrations at every nearby location. Noise data were not found.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

Until the source series is available, the reported percentages remain attributed agency figures. They cannot be independently recomputed from the public materials cited here.

For Msida, the Environmental Resources Authority project file includes the planning statement, which relies on 2019 traffic counts and anticipates reduced travel time and pollution [4]. The 2024 IM wording also forecasts lower noise. Those documents describe the case for a proposed project. They are not evidence of its operating performance.

3

Induced travel and what it means here

Duranton and Turner analysed US cities and found that added interstate lane-kilometres were associated with more vehicle-kilometres travelled [6]. This peer-reviewed evidence supports induced travel as a possible network-level response to added capacity. It is not a direct estimate for a junction in Malta.

The finding cautions against assuming that an initial local delay reduction will guarantee lasting network-wide congestion relief. It does not establish that Marsa had no local travel-time benefit, and it cannot tell us what happened at Msida. A junction-level analysis must distinguish new trips from route changes, time-of-day shifts, demographic growth and other network changes.

KEEP THE MEASURES DISTINCT

Journey time, queue length, traffic volume, tailpipe emissions, ambient pollutant concentrations and noise exposure are related but different outcomes. A before-and-after comparison should name the measure and show its place, time period and method.

4

Verdict and evidence needed

VERDICT

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

Plausible benefits and agency-reported estimates; independent outcome data remain unavailable.

Why. Infrastructure Malta reports large Marsa travel-time and emissions reductions, and a later news report says the agency cited periodic surveys. The underlying surveys and calculation methods were not located. For Msida, the statement was made before works began; although the flyover is in vehicle use, the broader project remained in progress in 2026 and no comparable post-opening traffic, air or noise series was found. The combined claim is therefore stronger than the public evidence that can be checked. Confidence is moderate because relevant agency claims and planning documents exist, but key data are missing.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say that the infrastructure had no local benefit or that the published figures are false. It says the cited public record does not let readers reproduce or independently assess the outcomes.

Evidence that would settle the open questions

- ☐ Release Marsa's raw traffic counts and travel-time survey methodology, including routes, dates, time windows, baseline adjustments and uncertainty.
- ☐ Show how each emissions percentage was derived; report monitor-based ambient concentrations separately from estimated emissions.
- ☐ Publish Msida post-opening traffic, air-quality and noise measurements after the full road arrangement is operating, with defined comparison locations and periods.
- ☐ Track junction and wider-network outcomes for several years, accounting for fleet/population growth and route or time shifts.

Right of reply. Not sought in this draft, at the maintainer's direction. Handle before wider circulation.

5

Sources

- [1] Infrastructure Malta, Msida Creek: enhancing connectivity and community spaces, 28 October 2024 (wording checked 5 October 2026). <https://www.infrastructuremalta.com/news/msida-creek-enhancing-connectivity-and-community-spaces>
- [2] Infrastructure Malta, Infrastructure Malta completes the Marsa Junction Project, 15 April 2021. <https://www.infrastructuremalta.com/news/infrastructure-malta-completes-marsa-junction-project>
- [3] Office of the Prime Minister, Inawgurata l-flyover tal-Imsida Creek, 17 December 2025 (Maltese). <https://primeminister.gov.mt/latest-news/pr252279/>
- [4] ERA, PA/02053/20 and PA/06425/20 project record and documents. https://era.org.mt/era-project/pa02053-20_pa06425-20/
- [5] Times of Malta, Roads agency insists Marsa junction cuts travel time by 70%, despite complaints, 29 November 2021 (secondary). <https://timesofmalta.com/article/roads-agency-insists-marsa-junction-cuts-travel-time-by-70-despite.913440>
- [6] Duranton & Turner, The Fundamental Law of Road Congestion: Evidence from US Cities, American Economic Review 101(6), 2616–2652 (2011). <https://doi.org/10.1257/aer.101.6.2616>

Version 1.1 · 5 October 2026 · Draft pending right of reply · Evidence register: <data/cc-008/assessment.csv>

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	2 Oct 2026	First issue. Right of reply not sought, at the maintainer's direction.
1.1	5 Oct 2026	Corrections: the Msida quotation now matches the wording on Infrastructure Malta's page (checked 5 October 2026); the earlier quotation included words ("this project", "which will be") not on the page as checked, and the forecast reading now rests on the statement having been published before works began. Added the Marsa release's wording on "significant air quality improvements in Paola and Marsa". Heading typo "Mars" corrected to "Marsa". Verdict and confidence unchanged.